# Setting up Microsoft Authenticator for multi-factor authentication

Article KB0010007 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: MFA / authenticator | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, iOS and Android smartphones, Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) + on-premises Active Directory

## Summary

This article guides users through setting up, moving, or troubleshooting Microsoft Authenticator for Acme Global's multi-factor authentication (MFA). It includes prerequisites, a step-by-step self-help procedure for enrolling a new device or recovering access, verification steps, common issue troubleshooting, and the exact process the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team follows when a ticket is escalated.

## Symptoms

- "We couldn't verify your identity" prompt when signing in
- No push notification or SMS code received on the phone
- Authenticator app shows a 6-digit code that is rejected as invalid
- Authenticator lists the wrong account or shows an expired credential
- User reports a lost or stolen phone and cannot complete MFA

## Common causes

- Device replaced or restored without re-registering the Authenticator app
- Phone time drift causing TOTP codes to be out of sync
- Backup SMS method not enabled or phone number changed
- Authenticator app data corrupted after OS update
- MFA registration blocked due to failed attempts or lockout

## Overview

Acme Global requires MFA for all corporate sign-ins using Microsoft Authenticator as the primary method, with SMS as a backup. When a user gets a new phone, loses their device, or experiences sync issues, they must re-register Authenticator after identity verification. This article provides the steps end-users can follow themselves and the exact workflow the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team uses when a ticket is raised.

## Prerequisites

Before starting, ensure you have:

- Access to your Acme Global corporate email (Outlook) and the ability to receive a verification code via your existing MFA method (if still working) or via a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) issued by IAM.
- The Microsoft Authenticator app installed from the Apple App Store or Google Play Store.
- A stable internet connection (Wi-Fi or cellular).
- If you are using a Windows laptop, confirm that the device is enrolled in Intune and that the Company Portal app is functional.

## Self-Help Procedure: Setting up or Moving Microsoft Authenticator

Follow these numbered steps to register or re-register Microsoft Authenticator on your new or existing device. If you still have access to your old phone and can approve a push notification, you can use that to verify your identity; otherwise, request a Temporary Access Pass from the IAM team via the IT Service Desk (phone 4357 or Teams channel "IT Help").

1. 1. Open a browser and go to the Microsoft My Account portal: https://myaccount.microsoft.com/security-info . Sign in with your Acme Global email address.
2. If prompted for MFA, choose the method you still have access to (e.g., SMS, phone call, or an existing Authenticator on another device). If you have no working method, select "I can't use any of these methods" and request a Temporary Access Pass from the IAM team (see the Service Desk Procedure section).
3. Once inside the Security info page, locate the "Microsoft Authenticator" entry. If it exists, select "Delete" to remove the old registration; confirm the deletion.

4. Choose "Add method" -> "Authenticator app" -> "Next".
5. On your smartphone, open the Microsoft Authenticator app, tap the "+" or "Add account", select "Work or school account", and then choose "Scan QR code".
6. Point the phone camera at the QR code displayed on the browser screen. The app will add your Acme Global account and show a six-digit code.
7. Back on the browser, click "Next". Enter the six-digit code shown in the Authenticator app and click "Next".
8. You should see a confirmation that the Authenticator app is successfully registered. Optionally, enable the backup SMS method by selecting "Add method" -> "Phone" and entering your mobile number.
9. Complete the setup by clicking "Done". Test the registration by signing out of any Acme Global service and signing back in; you should receive a push notification or be able to enter the code from Authenticator.

## Verification

After completing the self-help procedure, verify that MFA works as expected:
- Attempt to log in to Outlook on the web (https://outlook.office.com) or Teams desktop client.
- You should receive a push notification on your phone; approve it, or enter the six-digit code from Authenticator if prompted.
- If you enabled SMS backup, you can also choose "Sign in another way" -> "Text my phone" to receive a code.
- Successful login confirms that the Authenticator registration is correct and that time synchronization is adequate (the app automatically syncs time with Microsoft servers).

## Troubleshooting Common Issues

If you encounter problems after following the steps, try these remedies:

**No push notification or SMS received**
1. Ensure the phone has internet connectivity and that notifications are allowed for the Microsoft Authenticator app (Settings -> Apps -> Authenticator -> Notifications).
2. Verify that the phone's date and time are set to automatic; incorrect time causes TOTP codes to be out of sync.
3. If using SMS, confirm that the mobile number on file matches the SIM in the phone; update it via the My Account portal if needed.

**Authenticator code rejected as invalid**
1. Wait for the next code (codes change every 30 seconds).
2. Re-sync the app: open Authenticator, tap the three-dot menu -> "Settings" -> "Time correction for codes" -> "Sync now".
3. Delete and re-add the account following the self-help procedure.

**App shows the wrong account or duplicate entries**
1. Remove any duplicate or incorrect accounts from the Authenticator app (tap the account -> "Remove account").
2. Re-add the correct Acme Global account using the QR code method.

**Lost phone - cannot complete MFA**
1. Contact the IT Service Desk (phone 4357, Teams "IT Help") and request a Temporary Access Pass.
2. Provide your employee ID and answer the security questions used for identity verification.
3. Once you receive the TAP, use it to sign in to the My Account portal and re-register Authenticator on a new device following the self-help steps.

If none of these actions resolve the issue, proceed to the Service Desk Procedure section for escalation.

## Service Desk Procedure

When a user contacts the IT Service Desk with an MFA/Authenticator issue, the L1 agent follows this workflow before escalating to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. The agent must verify the user's identity according to Acme Global's security policy, then either guide the user through self-help steps or initiate a TAP issuance.

1. 1. Greet the user and confirm their name, employee ID, and department.
2. Ask the user to describe the symptom (e.g., "no push notification", "lost phone", "code not accepted").
3. Verify identity using one of the following methods (choose the first that is available):
   a. If the user can still approve a push notification on a trusted device, ask them to do so.
   b. If the user has access to their registered SMS backup, send a one-time passcode to that number and ask them to read it back.
   c. If neither of the above works, inform the user that a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) will be issued and place them on hold while you contact the IAM team via the designated Teams channel "IAM-Support" or by calling the IAM hotline (extension 4358).
4. Once identity is verified:
   - If the user still has a working MFA method, walk them through the Self-Help Procedure steps 1-9 (provided in this article) and ask them to test login.
   - If the user needs a new device registration, generate a TAP (valid for 24 hours, single-use) and communicate the passcode securely (via Teams chat or read aloud). Instruct the user to sign in to https://myaccount.microsoft.com/security-info using the TAP, then follow the Self-Help Procedure to add Authenticator.
5. After the user reports success, close the ticket with resolution note: "MFA re-registered via Authenticator after identity verification; user confirmed login success."
6. If the user cannot complete the steps despite a valid TAP (e.g., app crash, persistent time sync issue), escalate to the IAM team with the following details:
   - Employee ID and name
   - Description of the symptom and any error messages
   - Steps already attempted (including TAP usage)
   - Device make/model, OS version, and Authenticator app version
   - Attach any screenshots or logs if available
   The IAM team will investigate underlying account or token issues and may issue a new credential or reset the MFA registration at the directory level.

## When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team when:
- The user cannot verify identity via any existing MFA method and a Temporary Access Pass fails to allow re-registration.
- The Authenticator app repeatedly shows invalid codes despite time-sync attempts and reinstall.
- There is suspicion of a compromised account or a need to reset the MFA registration at the directory level.
When escalating, include the employee's name, ID, department, a concise symptom summary, error messages, the TAP used (if any), device details (make, model, OS version, Authenticator version), and a list of troubleshooting steps already performed. Attach screenshots of error messages or the Authenticator app screen if possible. Use the Teams channel "IAM-Support" or call the IAM hotline (extension 4358) and mark the ticket as high priority (P2) if the user is blocked from accessing critical resources.

*Keywords: Microsoft Authenticator, MFA setup, new phone, lost phone, authenticator not working, push notification not received, invalid authenticator code, time sync, temporary access pass, TAP, identity verification, self service password reset, sspr, multi factor authentication, authenticator app, account recovery, IAM, Identity & Access Management*